

How We Use the Self and What Does It Mean for Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · International Talks · 54:56

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammasambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Sammasambuddhassa*

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening we're going to look at how the Buddha talks about the self. And then, of course, he also talks about not-self. So it's a bit confusing, I think. When you first encounter Buddhism, you always hear about these three characteristics: suffering, impermanence, and not-self. And everyone says, "What? Not-self?" Even during the Buddha's time, many people were confused. Even in the Buddha's era, many people didn't really understand it.

The Jains and the Hindus believed in a self. The materialists of that time didn't believe in an eternal self. The Buddhists couldn't seem to make up their minds. It was very confusing. So let's look at how the Buddha uses the self.

One of the most well-known ways is his discourse to Ānanda, his advice to Ānanda: "Be an island unto yourself, be your own refuge, have no other. Let the Dhamma be an island and a refuge for you, have no other."

And then in the Dhammapada, it's full of this work of self. Glory grows for a person who is energetic and mindful, who is pure and conscious of their actions, restrained and vigilant, and who lives according to the Dhamma.

There's another one here: "Greater in battle than one who conquers a thousand times a thousand people is the person who conquers themselves."

And I'll just take one or two others: "By oneself, evil is done. By oneself alone, evil is done. It is born of oneself and produced by oneself. It wears down those who lack wisdom as a diamond can wear down a precious stone." These are all verses from the Dhammapada.

"It is up to you to make the effort. The *Tathāgatas*, the Buddhas, only tell you how."

And then there are also very famous, well-known verses that speak about *kamma*: "I am the owner of my *kamma*. I inherit my *kamma*. I am born of my *kamma*. I am related to my *kamma*. I am supported by my *kamma*. Whatever I do, for good or ill, of that I will be the heir."

So the Buddha doesn't deny that we have a sense of self. And he actually tells us to use it in a good way.

If we look at dependent origination, we'll see that this sense of self actually originates at a particular moment. The four middle links represent the process by which we know something. Everything we experience begins with a point of contact with one of the sense bases. For example, there must be a sound, a vibration, that reaches my ear before I can hear something. This is true for the five physical senses, but it's also true for the mind-heart. The mind is also seen as a sense base in which mental objects manifest.

From this first little perception, something manifests that is perceived as either pleasant or unpleasant. So the first step we translate as contact and the second as feeling tone. Something that isn't very clear in dependent origination is that with contact and feeling, there's also perception that manifests. In Buddhist psychology, feeling and perception manifest simultaneously.

We can think of perception as a photocopy. And this photocopy changes each time we have a perception that is similar. This is what we normally call a concept.

The next step is the normal reaction of wanting or not wanting, liking or not liking. It's only after this that the sense or view of self appears. So there's been a whole process of contact, feeling, perception, reaction, before this sense of self, of "me," of "me doing something," or "I want something" appears.

In English this is translated as *taṇhā* or "craving." In French, we normally use "soif" - thirst. It's a very, very strong desire. And once we've reached that point, it's very difficult not to move to the next step.

The next step is the act of will, the intention. This is the point of becoming, the point of action, the point of *kamma*. And once we've done that, we cannot stop the consequences.

So the sense of self is part of our psychology and the Buddha fully accepts this. Now, the idea is that once we have a sense of self, we can take control of our lives and recognize that we can change ourselves. We can see that the sense of self is, shall we say, a tactic. We can think of the self as a kind of tactic for changing our moral behavior so that it leads us toward liberation.

We can say that the Buddha's teaching concerns only two things: transcendence and also ethics, morality. And there's a connection between the two. Before looking at this connection more, there's a sutta, a very beautiful sutta, with someone called Vacchagotta.

So the sutta begins: the wanderer Vacchagotta went to the Buddha and paid homage to him. After exchanging welcoming and pleasant words, he sat to one side. And sitting there, he asked the Blessed One, "Now then, venerable Gotama, is there a self?" When this was said, the Buddha remained silent.

Then Vacchagotta asked, "Is there no self?" And for a second time, the Blessed One remained silent. And so Vacchagotta got up and left.

After this, the Venerable Ānanda asked the Blessed One, "Why didn't you answer?" The Buddha replied:

"Ānanda, if I had told Vacchagotta that the self exists, I would have sided with the brahmins and ascetics who follow the philosophy of eternalism. If I had answered that there was no self, that would correspond to the brahmins and contemplatives who are exponents of annihilation."

So here we have the Buddha not wanting to fall into a view about what is transcendent. That there is something transcendent, there's no denial of that. But he doesn't want to substantiate it as a thing, like a soul.

When it comes to Vacchagotta asking if there was no self, if I had answered that there was no self, he would have been really confused and would have thought, "But the self that I thought I had no longer exists."

We can see that this teaching wasn't obvious. So it's clear that the Buddha is actually talking about two different selves. The conventional self, the self that we think we are, he doesn't deny. What he says is that actually, it's impermanent. It manifests and it disappears, like everything else. And he also says that we should use this sense of self to guide us on the spiritual path.

How does he explain or demonstrate what is transcendent? One of the most well-known verses on this subject says: "There is the unborn, the unconditioned, the uncreated, the unbecome." The Pali word he uses in this case is *atthi*. The other Pali word that means "to be" is *hoti*. In Pali, when we use the word *hoti*, it's a word that connects things. So we say "this is a computer." But the word *atthi* means that it exists, that it truly exists.

And then he continues to say that if this didn't exist, there would be no escape from what is born, conditioned, created, and become.

There's another passage that makes even clearer that there is transcendence. He says that there exists a dimension where the sense bases - everything we experience must pass through the six senses - where there's also an experience that doesn't include the six senses. And then he says there's no moon, no sun, not even time. One doesn't come, one doesn't go, and one doesn't remain motionless.

And the last example that comes to mind is when someone asks him, "Where are the four elements destroyed?" What's interesting is this question about where the four elements are destroyed - the four elements meaning the physical world. The Buddha tells him he doesn't know, but that the highest gods will know.

This is Kevaddha. And so Kevaddha goes to see the highest devas to ask them the question, and they answer that they don't know, but that the gods who are higher, superior, will be able to answer this question. And so he goes to see the gods who are superior and they say the same thing: "But those who are even more refined than us will be able to answer this question."

And in this way, he goes higher and higher in the heavens, until he arrives at the highest level of heaven,

the most powerful. And the devas of this highest heaven tell him, "We don't know either, but the god Brahmā will know."

In a flash Brahmā manifests and Brahmā says, "I am Brahmā, I am the creator, I am the greatest, I am the most powerful, the creator of everything." And Kevaddha says to him, "I have a question for you: Where do the four great elements cease?"

And Brahmā simply responds, "I am Brahmā, I am the most powerful, the greatest, the creator of everything." And Kevaddha says, "I didn't ask you who you were or what you were. I want to know where the four elements come to an end."

But Brahmā answers the same thing. And then the third time, he takes the monk aside to speak to him privately. He says to him, "Listen, I don't know, but I don't want all the other gods and devas to know. The one who can answer this question is actually the Bhagavat, the Buddha. So go back to see him and ask him the question."

The discourses are full of this kind of humor where the Buddha mocks a little the Brahmanical religion, and he does the same thing when he talks about castes.

And so Kevaddha goes to see the Buddha and the Buddha actually adds something to the question: "Where do the four elements and the *nāma-rūpa*, the mind-body, find no foothold? They find no place to land, to be." Then he says that there is a consciousness that is not touched by the senses. It has no limits. This consciousness is full of light in all directions.

And so here we have the Buddha trying to express, using the words of his time, something that didn't exist in his time. It's the same way that Freud had to invent new words like ego, id, and superego to explain his vision.

So this consciousness is not the same as ordinary consciousness. It can't be since it doesn't manifest and it doesn't disappear.

And I like to use the myth of Narcissus to explain this. So the story of Narcissus: he looks into a pond, and he sees his reflection and falls in love with himself. And he's so in love, so taken by this image, that he leans over to kiss it, and he falls into the pond and drowns. Now, in mythology, water is what is created.

And so what we experience within us is something that observes and that feels and that has this sense of self, this reflection of itself. When we meditate, we turn toward all our experiences. And when we do that, we have a very powerful sense of being the one who observes, the one who investigates, the one who feels. Is that right? Is that how you feel it?

So this sense of self is Narcissus looking into the pond and perceiving his image as in a mirror. He's enchanted by what he sees in the mind, in the heart, in the mind-body-heart. And so this great understanding dives into the created world. And so this attention, this mindfulness plunges into the

created world of this organism.

And so what knows experiences itself on the screen of consciousness, which corresponds to the surface of the pond. And it's enchanted by what it sees, and so is plunged into the world that is created by this organism.

So this happens in your meditation when you observe, for example, a sensation, fatigue, a very beautiful feeling in your heart. And so here we have an awareness that is conscious of itself on the screen of consciousness. And on this screen, we also see what the organism feels - it also feels the joy that is in the heart. And so on this screen, it also feels the peace that is in the heart. When we spoke of tranquillity, we feel a joy in the heart.

I notice this appears to be French text rather than English, and it seems to be a different talk or speaker than the context provided (which mentioned Bhante Bodhidharma teaching in English).

Could you please clarify:

1. Is this the correct text you'd like me to edit?
2. Should I be editing French text or English text?
3. Is this part of the same talk about "How we use the self and what does it mean for not-self"?

The text appears to be discussing meditation and awakening in French, but given the context you provided was about an English-speaking teacher, I want to make sure I'm working with the right material before proceeding.

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